

The House That Remembered My Name

Part II: The Rooms That Shouldn't Exist

The hand on mine was impossibly cold.

Not the chill of winter.

Not the dampness of rain.

It was the kind of cold that belonged to something untouched by sunlight for generations.

I couldn't move.

Every muscle in my body locked into place while my heartbeat pounded against my ribs.

Then the voice spoke again.

"Turn around."

It wasn't a command.

It was a promise.

Slowly, I turned.

No one stood behind me.

The bedroom was empty.

Moonlight poured through the cracked window, illuminating the old rocking horse, the faded wallpaper, and the diary still open on the bed.

The only evidence that anything had happened was a thin layer of frost spreading across the wooden floor where my feet had been.

I stumbled backward.

"Who's there?"

Silence.

Then, somewhere deep inside the mansion...

A door slammed.

Another followed.

Then another.

One after another, dozens of heavy doors echoed through the house until the walls trembled.

The sound ended as suddenly as it had begun.

The mansion became silent again.

Too silent.

Daniel stuffed the diary into his backpack.

If there were answers inside this house, they wouldn't reveal themselves willingly.

He left the bedroom and returned to the hallway.

Only...

The hallway wasn't the same one he'd entered.

The wallpaper had changed.

The portraits were gone.

The windows had disappeared.

Instead, candles lined both sides of the corridor, each burning with a pale blue flame.

There had been no candles before.

He looked behind him.

The bedroom door was gone.

Only a smooth wall remained.

His breathing became uneven.

"No..."

He ran forward.

Every twenty steps another door appeared.

Every door carried a brass number.

12

11

10

They counted downward.

The further he walked, the colder the air became.

By the time he reached Door Number Five, his breath hung like fog.

Behind Door Number Four...

Someone knocked.

Three slow knocks.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Daniel froze.

The knocking came again.

Then a quiet voice.

"Please..."

It sounded exactly like him.

Against every instinct, he reached for the handle.

The metal was warm.

He opened the door.

The room beyond wasn't part of the mansion.

It was his apartment.

His own living room.

Exactly as he'd left it three days earlier.

His coffee mug sat on the table.

His laptop remained open.

His jacket hung beside the entrance.

Everything was perfect.

Except...

Someone was inside.

A man stood with his back toward Daniel, looking out the apartment window.

He wore Daniel's clothes.

Daniel's shoes.

Daniel's watch.

Slowly...

The man turned.

It was Daniel.

Not similar.

Not a twin.

It was him.

The other Daniel smiled sadly.

"You shouldn't have come."

The room vanished.

The door slammed shut.

Daniel found himself back in the corridor, gasping for air.

Hours—or perhaps minutes—passed.

Time had become unreliable.

His watch no longer moved.

His phone displayed only one number.

3:13

No battery icon.

No date.

Only the time.

Always the same time.

Eventually, he discovered the mansion's library.

Towering shelves reached toward a ceiling hidden in darkness.

Thousands of books filled the room.

None had titles.

Only years.

1874.

1898.

1912.

1939.

1978.

2004.

2026.

Daniel reached for the newest volume.

The cover felt strangely warm.

He opened it.

The first page read:

Daniel Carter entered Blackwood House at 5:41 P.M.

His stomach tightened.

He turned the page.

The story continued.

Every step he'd taken since arriving.

Every conversation.

Every thought.

Word for word.

He flipped ahead.

The pages described him standing in the library reading the book.

His breathing became faster.

He skipped further.

The writing continued.

Then...

Halfway through the next page...

The text ended.

Only one unfinished sentence remained.

Daniel looked behind him and finally saw...

Blank.

The remaining pages were empty.

Something breathed against the back of his neck.

Very slowly...

He closed the book.

"I know you're there," he whispered.

No answer.

He turned.

No one.

But another book had appeared on the table.

Smaller.

Older.

Its leather cover carried only one word.

REMEMBER.

Inside were photographs.

Not printed photographs.

Real ones.

Each showed Daniel at different ages.

Five years old.

Twelve.

Seventeen.

Twenty-six.

Yet every picture had been taken inside Blackwood House.

Impossible.

He had never been here before.

Had he?

A memory surfaced without warning.

A woman humming softly.

The scent of lavender.

A grand staircase.

A little girl laughing.

It lasted less than a second.

Then vanished.

Leaving only a headache so severe Daniel dropped to one knee.

The mansion wasn't giving him memories.

It was taking them back.

As midnight approached, the mansion changed again.

Furniture shifted.

Walls groaned.

Portraits returned.

Only now...

Every face had eyes.

And every pair of eyes watched him.

Wherever he walked, the painted figures turned ever so slightly.

Not enough to notice immediately.

Just enough to make certainty impossible.

Daniel entered the ballroom.

Moonlight streamed through towering windows.

At its center stood a magnificent chandelier.

Beneath it waited dozens of elegantly dressed figures.

Motionless.

Men.

Women.

Children.

All wearing black.

Their backs faced him.

None moved.

None breathed.

The air smelled faintly of old roses.

A gramophone began playing somewhere in the darkness.

A slow waltz echoed through the room.

Without warning...

Every figure raised its head simultaneously.

Not turning.

Simply lifting.

As if listening.

Then one by one...

They began to dance.

Partners gliding across the floor with perfect grace.

Their movements made no sound.

No footsteps.

No rustling clothes.

Only music.

Daniel stepped backward.

One dancer stopped.

Then another.

Soon every couple stood perfectly still.

Without turning around...

They spoke together.

"One partner is missing."

The music stopped.

Every figure slowly rotated toward him.

None had faces.

Only smooth, pale skin where eyes, noses, and mouths should have been.

Except one.

Standing in the center.

A young boy.

Blue eyes.

The same face from the portraits.

Daniel's face.

The boy smiled.

"I've been waiting."

The boy reached into his pocket and removed a small brass key.

"I think this belongs to you."

Daniel accepted it before realizing what he'd done.

The key was engraved with a single number.

13

"What does it open?"

The boy's smile faded.

"It opens the room you locked."

"I don't understand."

"You will."

The chandelier flickered.

When Daniel blinked...

The ballroom was empty.

The faceless dancers were gone.

The music had ended.

Only the brass key remained in his trembling hand.

A low rumble shook the mansion.

Somewhere below the floor, gears began turning.

Ancient machinery groaned to life.

Dust rained from the ceiling.

At the far end of the corridor, a wall slowly split apart, revealing a staircase descending into complete darkness.

The brass key grew warm.

As though recognizing where it belonged.

Daniel knew, with terrifying certainty, that he had reached the part of the house that wasn't meant to exist.

And somewhere beneath those ancient floorboards...

Room Thirteen was waiting.

Waiting not to trap him.

But to remind him of something he had chosen to forget.

As he placed one foot onto the first stone step, a whisper floated upward from the darkness.

Not frightening.

Not angry.

Heartbroken.

"Please remember why you buried us."

The staircase trembled.

Behind him, every door in the mansion slammed shut.

There would be no easy way back.

Daniel tightened his grip on the brass key and descended into the dark.

Above him, the house sighed with quiet satisfaction.

It had not captured another visitor.

It had welcomed home its last missing resident.

End of Part II